My project, titled *Psilt* (found here), is an interactive multimedia webpage based around my experience moving to Montreal and how it has shaped the construction of my identity. In *Psilt* I invite the user to participate in the process of building a personal narrative to the outside world. An ambiguous interrogator asks the user questions. With no other option but to respond the user types. Every keystroke presents a radically new perspective. As the user responds, a model of the world is built in their mind, along with a body. The interrogator trails off and the user is left to continue typing or abandon the project.

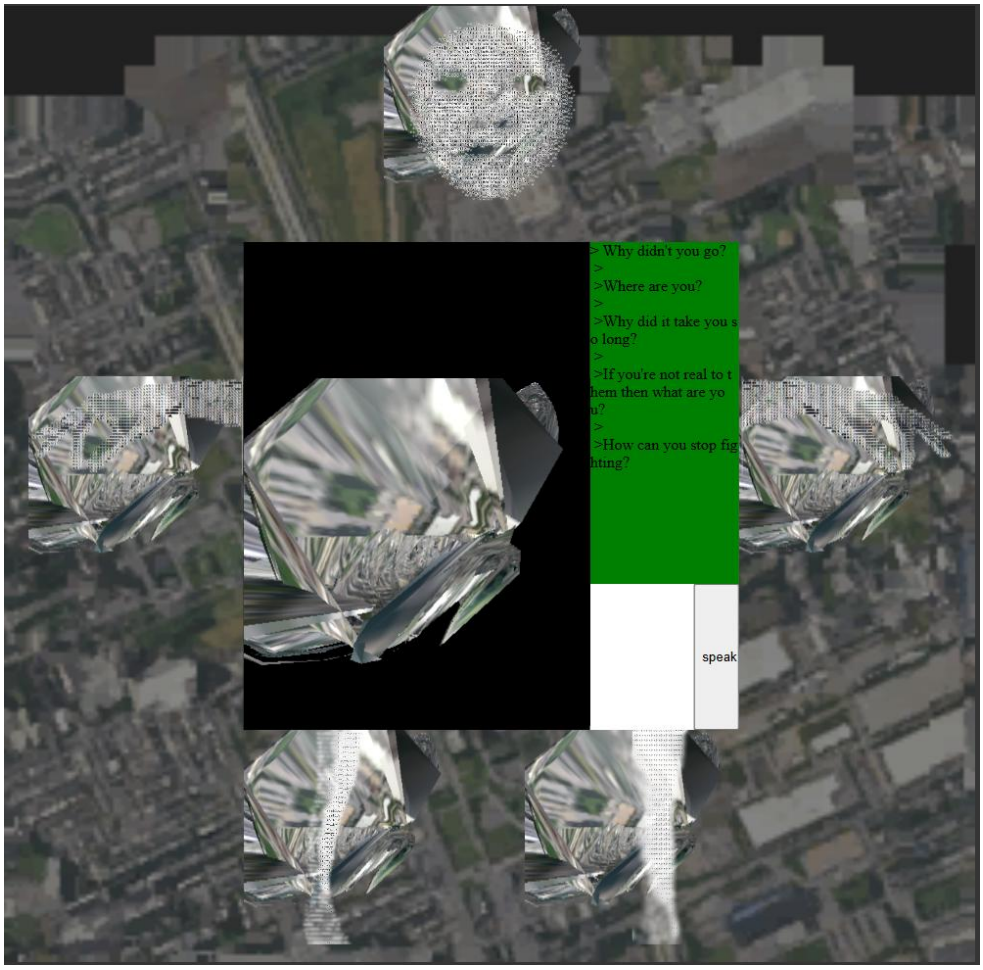
With *Psilt* I hoped to balance a diaristic project with a more direct exploration of how to get a viewer to build a body and identity in a short time frame. It acts as a reflection on my time living in Montreal: my transition to adulthood, a grappling with my gender identity, a struggle for consistency, and cumulatively figuring out how I live and exist in relation to others and myself. A 3D map of Montreal swirls in the center of a digital body. Blocks of the webpage make it up. The body is intangible and fluid (try resizing the browser window). The user's connection to it is mediated by their ability to parse what's in front of them. It's not a complete model of myself/oneself and it never will be, but actions build it out.

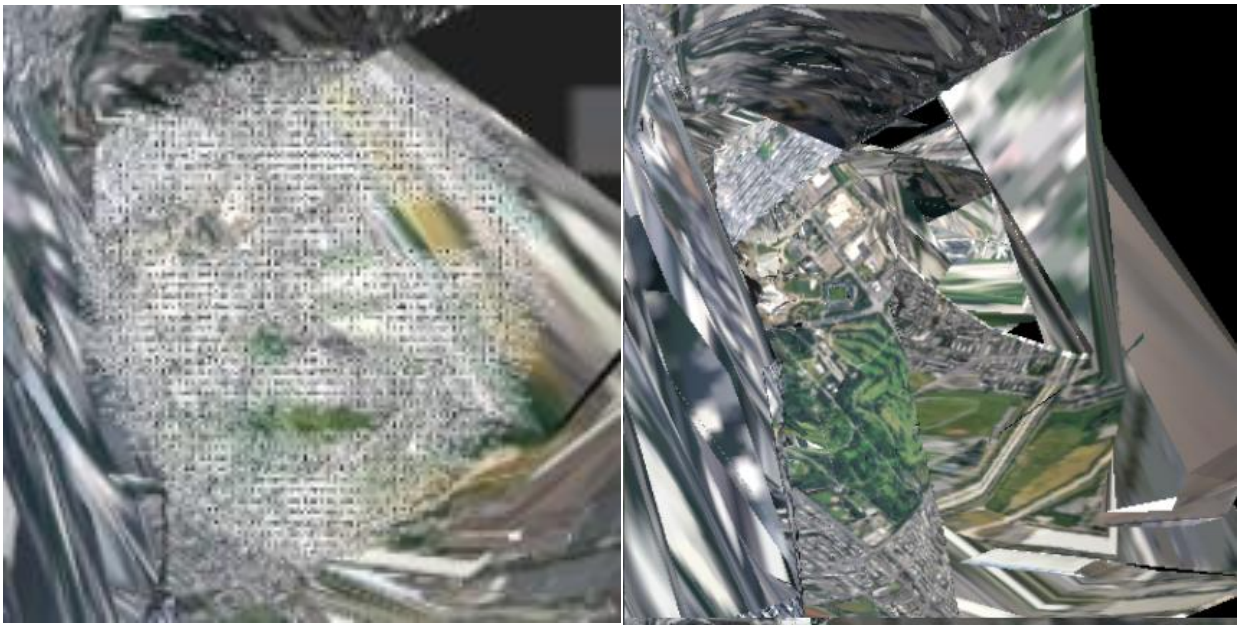
Regarding technical details, I built the project using three.js. I wanted to create a dynamic and animated way to warp a model depending on input, so I worked on getting the Flow modifier working. Because I wanted to use a custom model I had to go through the process of extracting the geometry from the three.js 3Dobject and getting it to display properly. I had to learn how to traverse 3Dobject and mesh data, as well as use async functions to prevent errors. I also spent time refining the CSS for this project so that the layout reacts dynamically, both for consistency and because the piece gains meaning from the 'body' parts staying properly attached with scaling. I talk about it more later, but although it isn't hooked up properly to the existing code, the script also has code to connect to a Meshtastic node and read serial data. I needed to figure out how to use the Web Serial API and data streams to get this working.

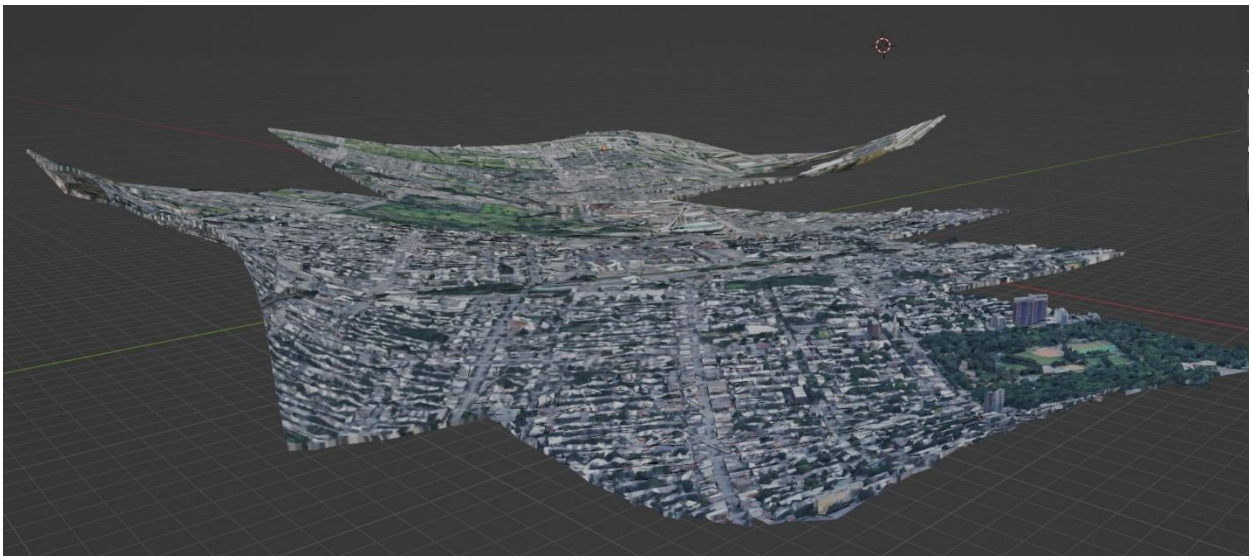
I'm interested in web art as a medium because I think that it offers a lot of room for valuable exploration. Digital media makes our world more than ever. Writers like Jean Baudrillard and Hito Steryl serve as major inspirations. I like working with the relationship between tangible and intangible, simulation and simulacra of the "real" world. For example, I engage with the concept of Jorge Borges' fictional 1:1 map from "On Exactitude in Science". My understanding of the physical shape of Montreal has been built just as much by the enormous Google Maps 3D model (the same as the one in *Psilt*) as it has by walking around. Both are just as real to me. Likewise, I engage the user in the process of constructing their own rudimentary version of myself. How is this version of me more or less real than the one in my project?

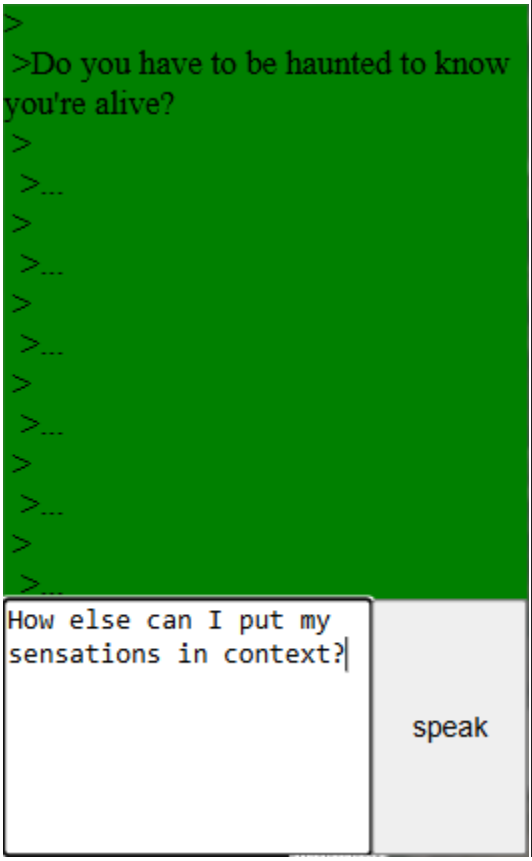
A project that also served as major inspiration is the early web art piece *Brandon* by Shu Lea Cheang. Cheang wanted to discuss the bodies we construct online- the “digi gender social body” by expressing a digital/performance narrative that allowed a user to explore the constructed identity of an individual. It was inspired by Brandon Teena, a trans man who was murdered in Nebraska. Cheang’s work on *Brandon* as well as *Garlic = Rich Air* served as major turning points in my understanding of digital art. The context of networks and computers are fundamental parts of digital art, it’s important to meaningfully engage with it.

The project also loops into another larger project I’m working on called the Gestural Meshnet. Essentially it is an open radio-based chat room that artworks can communicate with each other in. For example, *Psilt* could send the text a user writes to a robot that would then move in correspondence to the words. Or, a user hums into a microphone and *Psilt* reacts by changing the shape of the map. It’s based on the idea of interpreting data from unknown sources and capturing human gestures in a digital network. The identity you construct in *Psilt* would be accessed and acted upon by others simply by virtue of existing.










```
let flowStart;
let map;
let curve = new THREE.CatmullRomCurve3([
    new THREE.Vector3(0, 5, 3),
    new THREE.Vector3(0, 0, 10),
    new THREE.Vector3(0, 5, 12),
    new THREE.Vector3(0, 0, 5)
], true);
curve.tension = .1;

async function loadMap() {
    const loader = new GLTFLoader();
    loader.frustumCulled = false;
    const mapData = await loader.loadAsync('media/postermap.glb');
    const mapModel = mapData.scene.children[0];
    //mapModel.frustumCulled = false;
    //console.log(mapData.scene.children[0]);
    return mapModel;
}
async function setupMap() {
    map = await loadMap();
    map.scale.set(.06, .06, .06);
    map.position.set(0, 0, 0);
    map.frustumCulled = false;
    map.rotation.z = Math.PI / 3;
    //scene.add(map);
    flowStart = new Flow(map);
    scene.add(flowStart.object3D);
    flowStart.updateCurve(0, curve);
    flowStart.object3D.traverse(function (child) {
        child.frustumCulled = false;
    })

}
setupMap();
console.log(flowStart);
```